MMK280 Brand Management

Brand Audit and Launch Activation

The Pokémon Company

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1. Background

- **Company Background**

The Pokémon Company was established in Japan in 1998 to manage the Pokémon brand, which originated with Pokémon Red and Green in 1996. The company manages video games, the Pokémon Trading Card Game, animation, mobile applications, merchandise, licensing and retail, developing Pokémon into a global entertainment brand (The Pokémon Company, 2024).

Figure 1: Pokémon Brand Ecosystem
Source: (The Pokemon Company, 2024)

- **Market Situation**

Pokémon holds a strong position in the global entertainment market. More than 85 billion Pokémon Trading Card Game cards have been distributed across over 90 countries and regions (The Pokémon Company, 2026). The brand generated approximately US$12 billion in licensed retail sales and ranked seventh in License Global's Top Global Licensors 2025 (Hart, 2026). Within trading cards, Pokémon ranked second by GMV on TCGplayer in Q2 2026, while competitors include Magic: The Gathering, Yu-Gi-Oh! and emerging creature-collection games such as Palworld (Day, 2026; Velzen, 2024).

- **Brand Vision**

The Pokémon Company Group's vision is "Bringing the world together through Pokémon" (The Pokémon Company, n.d.). This reflects its aim to connect consumers across countries, generations and shared interests. Pokémon GO demonstrates this through social interaction and community experiences (Lawler-Sagarin et al., 2023).

2. Consumer Profile and Positioning Strategy

Psychographic
Values: Social connection, entertainment, self-expression.
Aspirations: Connect through shared interests.
Anxieties/Challenges: Limited income, expects fresh experiences.
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Background

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Personal Preferences
1. Social

2. Curious

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Key Characteristics
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Buyer Behaviour
Purchase occasion: New Pokémon releases, special editions, events.
Benefits sought: Entertainment, social connection and discovery.

User status: Existing Pokémon fan
Usage rate: Regular user

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2.2. Point of Parity

Pokémon shares associations with interactive entertainment and collectible franchises, including gaming, character-based entertainment and collecting. Similar to Yu-Gi-Oh! and Palworld, Pokémon offers distinctive characters, interactive gameplay and collecting, establishing its membership within the entertainment and collectible market.

2.3. Point of Difference

Pokémon differentiates through its collectible creatures and consumer connections. Its "Gotta Catch 'Em All!" concept reinforces discovery and collecting across games, trading cards and animation (Sheldon, 2026; Saxena, 2024). Combined with its three-decade history, these strengthen nostalgia and differentiate Pokémon through collectability and emotional connection (Amano, 2022).

2.4. Perceptual Map

Table 1: Perceptual Map of Pokémon

2.5. Brand Mantra

	Emotional Modifier	Descriptive Modifier	Brand Function
Pokémon	Joyful	Shared	Discovery

3. Brand Inventory
Table 2: Pokémon Brand Element Evaluation

Brand Element	Memorability	Meaningfulness	Likeability	Transferability	Adaptability	Protectability
Brand name: Pokémon	Distinctive and recognisable (Arbitration and Mediation Center, 2001)	Reflects "Pocket Monsters" (Amadi, 2024).	Builds positive familiarity.	Works across brand categories.	Relevant across generations.	Trademark protected (Arbitration and Mediation Center, 2001)
Logo: Pokémon Wordmark	Distinctive colours support recognition (Peate, 2021).	Signals brand variety (Song et al., 2022).	Supports favourable attitudes (Song et al., 2022).	Works across brand touchpoints.	Retains core visual identity.	Trademark protected (Pokémon, n.d.).
Symbol: Poké Ball	Simple, distinctive visual cue.	Symbolises catching and collecting. Allison (2006).	Approachable circular design (Jiang et al., 2016).	Works across brand categories.	Retains recognisable form.	Registered trademark (USPTO, 2026).
Characters: Pikachu	Strong visual recognition (Gomez et al., 2019).	Represents companionship (Tobin, 2004).	Supports emotional appeal (Tobin, 2004).	Works across brand categories.	Adaptable yet recognisable.	Proprietary character. (Arbitration and Mediation Center, 2001)
Slogans: "Gotta Catch 'Em All!"	Recognisable Pokémon expression (Katsuno & Maret, 2004).	Communicates collecting (Allison, 2006).	Encourages engagement (Allison, 2006).	Works across media.	Reused in new campaigns (Pokémon, 2025).	Distinctive slogan.
Jingle: Pokémon center healing sound	Strengthens audio recognition (Jackson, 2003).	Signals recovery during gameplays (Collins, 2013).	Reinforces positive experiences (Collins, 2013).	Works across games.	Adapts to audio styles.	Proprietary audio asset.
Video Game Packaging	Consistent visuals aid recognition.	Communicates game identity.	Creates visual appeal. (Orth & Malkewitz, 2008)	Works across game releases.	Artwork evolves by release.	Uses protected brand assets.

Table 3: Pokémon Brand Elements and 7Ps

7Ps	Brand Element Application	Consumer Meaning & Appeal
Product	Logo, characters and symbols appear across games and merchandise.	Reinforces familiarity and collecting.
Price	Products are offered at different price points.	Improves accessibility for young adults with limited income.
Place	Brand elements remain consistent across channels.	Supports recognition across touchpoints.
Promotion	Pikachu, logo and slogan appear across campaigns.	Appeals through familiarity and nostalgia.
People	Characters and symbols are shared across fan communities.	Supports social connection.
Process	Familiar visual and audio cues support brand interactions.	Creates a consistent Pokémon experience.
Physical Evidence	Packaging and merchandise display Pokémon visual assets.	Makes brand identity tangible.

Overall, these brand elements strongly appeal to young-adult fans through familiarity, nostalgia, collecting and social connection.

4. Brand Exploratory

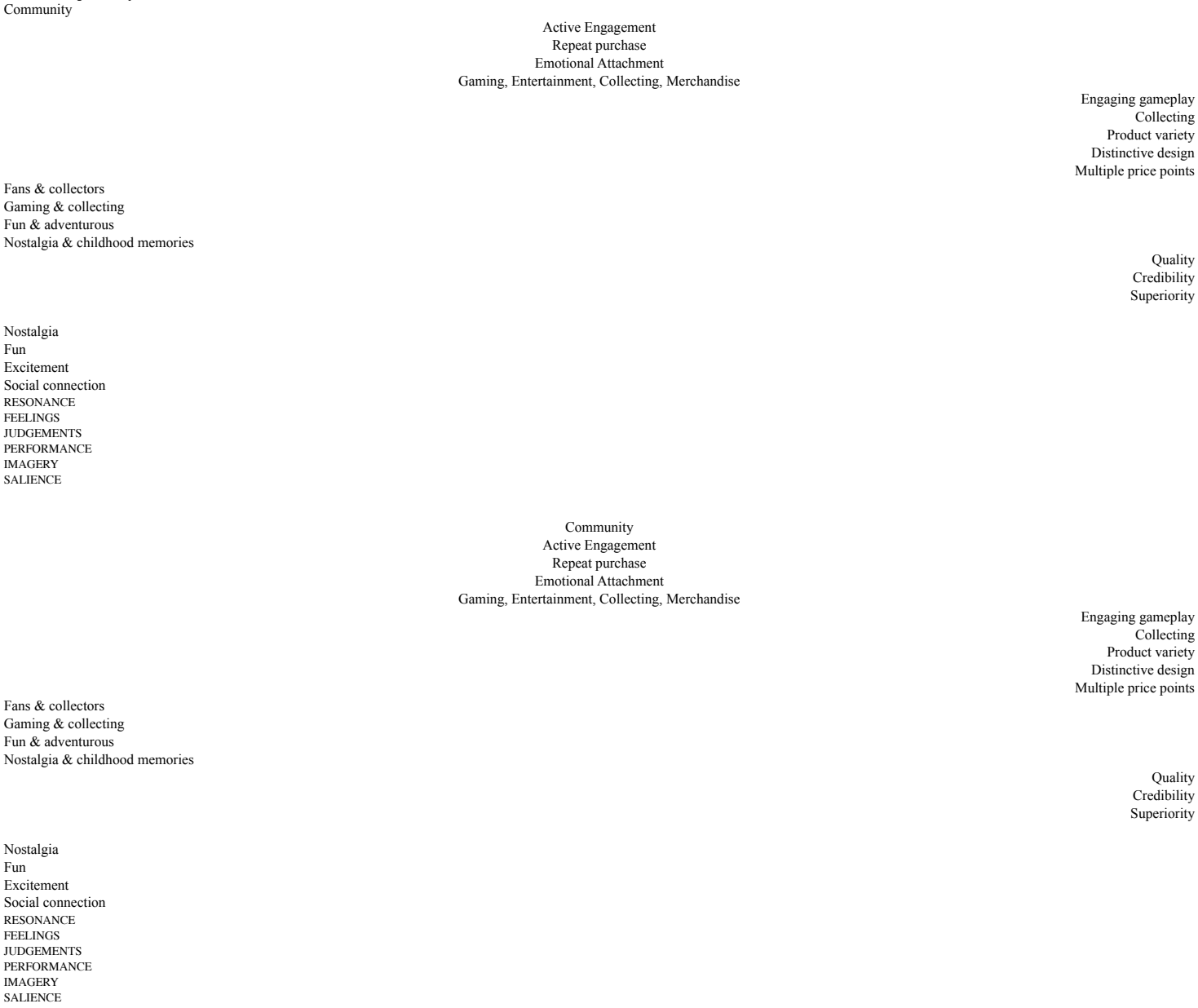


Figure 3: Pokémon CBBE Framework

4.1. Brand Identity

4.1.1. Brand Salience

Pokémon demonstrates strong depth of awareness, with experienced adults showing distinct and consistent visual responses to Pokémon following extensive childhood exposure (Gomez et al., 2019). However, this evidence primarily represents existing fans. Pokémon also maintains broad awareness across different consumption contexts, with current consumer engagement spanning trading cards, video games and online communities (Amarotti & Gaillot, 2026).

4.2. Brand Meaning

4.2.1. Brand Performance

Pokémon delivers performance through diverse game features, including collecting, battling, exploration and social interaction, providing multiple ways for young-adult fans to engage with the brand (Assunção et al., 2017). Catching new Pokémon particularly influences player behaviour (Arjoranta et al., 2020). However, performance quality is inconsistent, as Pokémon Scarlet received a 3.5/10 user score, with consumers frequently criticising technical issues and graphics (Metacritic, 2022).

4.2.2. Brand Imagery

Pokémon's imagery reflects a fan and collector culture, with gaming, collecting and trading forming key consumer practices (Allison, 2006). Its imagery is also shaped by childhood experiences, as childhood brand nostalgia influences consumers' beliefs about Pokémon (Harborth & Pape, 2019). Together, these associations reinforce Pokémon's playful and adventurous image, although nostalgia may be less relevant to newer consumers.

4.3. Brand Responses

4.3.1. Brand Judgements

Pokémon generates mixed consumer judgements. Quality is weakened by technical issues in recent games (Metacritic, 2022), while its long-established presence may contribute to perceived credibility. Its distinctive collecting culture and nostalgic value strengthen superiority among existing fans (Allison, 2006; Harborth & Pape, 2019), although these advantages may be less meaningful to new consumers.

4.3.2. Brand Feelings

For existing young-adult fans, Pokémon evokes nostalgia, fun, excitement and social connection. Childhood brand nostalgia strengthens their emotional response to Pokémon (Harborth & Pape, 2019), while collecting and trading create opportunities for shared experiences with other fans (Allison, 2006). These feelings align strongly with the target consumer's desire for entertainment, discovery and social connection.

4.4. Brand Relationship

4.4.1. Brand Resonance

Pokémon demonstrates strong resonance among existing young-adult fans through long-term loyalty and active engagement. Most respondents continued playing Pokémon despite many beginning with earlier generations (Assunção et al., 2017). Fans also create communities, tournaments and online content beyond official products (Assunção et al., 2017; Geraghty, 2017), demonstrating an enduring relationship that extends beyond purchase.

5. Launch Activation Strategy

5.1 Launch Activation Concept

The brand exploratory identified an opportunity to convert Pokémon's strong recognition and nostalgic associations among existing young-adult fans into renewed engagement with the brand. The proposed activation, There's Only One Pokémon, uses these established associations to generate interest in Pokémon Wind and Waves. The controversy surrounding Palworld's similarities to Pokémon generated substantial online attention, creating an opportunity to use this existing discourse as a social media hook (Galante, 2024). By directly comparing the two brands, the activation aims to reignite this existing debate, encouraging fans to comment, share and express their perceptions of Pokémon. This creates the potential for a new wave of social media discussion while redirecting attention towards Pokémon Wind and Waves.

5.2 Target Audience Alignment

The activation targets young-adult Pokémon fans aged 18-24 who grew up with the franchise and continue to engage with gaming and collecting. Childhood brand nostalgia influences young adults' perceptions of Pokémon (Harborth & Pape, 2019), making familiar characters such as Pikachu an effective cue for reconnecting with previous experiences. The Pokémon–Palworld comparison provides a fresh and provocative social media hook, aligning with the target audience's interest in gaming content and online discussion. The catching and collecting message also reconnects them with familiar Pokémon experiences, while the interactive format encourages commenting and sharing with others. This combination also addresses the target consumer's expectation for fresh experiences. While Pikachu and catching provide familiarity and nostalgia, the Palworld comparison introduces a more current and unexpected element. The activation therefore balances familiarity with novelty, helping the new release feel connected to consumers' existing Pokémon experiences without simply repeating them.

5.3 Brand Touchpoints

The activation will run across TikTok, Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts, reaching the target audience on platforms they regularly use through short-form content. The opening question encourages viewers to stop, recognise and compare the characters. Consumers are then exposed to nostalgic catching and collecting scenes before the reveal of Pokémon Wind and Waves. A call-to-action directs interested consumers to the official game page to learn more about the new release. Comments and shares extend the comparison beyond the original video, potentially generating further discussion around Pokémon and Palworld.

5.4 Marketing Communications Design

The video uses a short-form, fast-paced format designed to capture attention within the first few seconds. Pikachu and a similar-looking Palworld character appear side by side with the question, "In your mind, which one is Pikachu?" The video then zooms in on Pikachu before transitioning to Poké Balls and familiar catching and collecting scenes with the message, "When was the last time you caught a Pokémon?" The video transitions into Pokémon Wind and Waves gameplay, followed by "Do you want to catch them again?" Consistent use of Pokémon characters, visual elements and familiar experiences maintains brand recognition while connecting nostalgia directly to the new game.

Figure 4: Visual Similarity Between Sparkit and Pikachu
Source: (Greenwald, 2024)

5.5 Evaluation and Justification

The activation builds on the CBBE strengths identified in the brand exploratory while addressing the opportunity to convert existing awareness and nostalgia into renewed engagement. Rather than creating new associations, the activation uses familiar brand assets and experiences already meaningful to existing fans. The communication moves consumers from recognising Pikachu, to recalling catching and collecting experiences, and finally to discovering Pokémon Wind and Waves. This allows existing associations with Pokémon to be transferred to the new release. Using Pikachu as the opening cue reinforces brand salience through a highly recognizable character. Familiar catching and collecting experiences strengthen brand meaning by reinforcing associations already connected with Pokémon. The nostalgic transition is designed to generate positive brand responses among young-adult fans before connecting these associations with Pokémon Wind and Waves. Finally, the interactive comparison encourages consumers to participate and engage with the campaign, supporting stronger brand resonance. Effectiveness can be evaluated through video completion rate, engagement rate, click-throughs to the game page.

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